On Silence and Solitude

From "Silence as Sacrament," part of the *Reflections in Christ* series by Fr. John Breck, February 1, 2003. The complete article can be found at http://oca.org/reflections/fr.-john-breck/silence-as-sacrament

"Silence is the sacrament of the world to come."
(St. Isaac the Syrian)

Silence is not just the absence of ambient noise.
Nor does it mean the lack of laughter or music or shared reflection.

Silence is a state of mind and heart, a condition of the soul. It is inner stillness.

Silence in heaven reigns amidst joyous song and ceaseless celebration.
It is awe in the presence of the Divine.

Silence in this world leads us beyond earthquake, storm and fire, beyond stress, anguish and pain.
It makes audible, words of ineffable beauty.

Silence lets us hear the still small voice of God.

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Silence and stillness are essential to attain spiritual knowledge, to engage in spiritual warfare against the passions and against demonic powers, and to allow the voice of God to be heard. Silence and stillness nevertheless require a certain degree of solitude, a temporary withdrawing from the noise and busyness of the world that cause endless distractions and hinder us in our quest for God. "A brother came to Scetis to visit Abba Moses and asked him for a word. The old man said to him, 'Go, sit in your cell, and your cell will teach you everything.'"

Perhaps the greatest challenge to authentic Orthodox Christian life today, at least in the United States, is to transform the heart and mind, our inner being, into a place of silence and solitude. Silence enables us to hear ineffable speech, the words of God that touch, guide and heal, while solitude makes us aware of the discreet yet infinitely powerful presence of the One who is with us "until the end of the age." These two virtues, silence and solitude, enable us to transcend the emptiness of our life. They open the way to a new state of being that to most people seems paradoxical and unattainable: "to be alone yet know no loneliness."

In the noise and confusion of the world around us, apprenticeship in the virtues of silence and solitude transforms us at the deepest level of our being. By the grace of God, it creates of the heart of every person who seeks it, a sacred space, an interior monastic cell, a dwelling place for the Spirit of Truth, who teaches, guides, preserves and blesses us as we journey toward the Kingdom of Heaven.